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Chicago family trip

Four days of museums, lakefront parks, and dinner with friends in Evanston, for two boys aged 7 and 9.

Arrive
Southwest WN 2133, Wed Nov 4, 5:05 PM, Midway

Depart
Southwest WN 2939, Sat Nov 7, 2:55 PM, Midway

Stay
Wed: Staypineapple, The Loop. Thu–Fri: Hyatt Regency McCormick Place

Sunset
About 4:35 PM

Wed Nov 4 | Thu Nov 5 | Fri Nov 6 | Sat Nov 7 | Good to know

Wed, Nov 4

Arrival night

5:05 PM

Land at Midway

Southwest flight WN 2133. Rideshare to the hotel takes about 30–45 min in rush hour.

Transit: Orange Line to Washington/Wabash, then a 2-block walk (about 35 min, no transfers). Fine with rolling bags.

6:15 PM

Check in at Staypineapple

In the Loop at State and Washington. Drop bags and get settled.

7:00 PM

Deep-dish dinner at Giordano's

About a 10-minute walk east on Randolph. Call ahead, since deep dish takes about 40 minutes to bake.

Thu, Nov 5

Rooftop brunch and a walk through the city

8:15 AM

Check out of Staypineapple

Ask the front desk to hold your bags until about 4:30.

8:30 AM

Light breakfast at Goddess and the Baker

Pastries, breakfast sandwiches, and coffee. Keep it light, since brunch is at 11.

Transit: A 5-minute walk south on Wabash from Staypineapple.

9:15 AM

Maggie Daley Park

Climbing walls and a huge playground. A good way to burn energy before brunch.

Transit: A 10-minute walk east from Goddess and the Baker.

10:00 AM

Millennium Park & the Bean

Cross the BP Pedestrian Bridge from Maggie Daley Park. See your reflection in the Bean and the Crown Fountain faces.

Transit: A 5-minute walk over the BP Pedestrian Bridge from Maggie Daley Park.

10:30 AM

Chicago Cultural Center

Free. See the giant Tiffany glass dome, just across Michigan Ave from Cindy’s.

11:00 AM

Brunch at Cindy’s Rooftop

Opens at 11. Views over Millennium Park and the lake. Reserve the 11:00 slot on OpenTable.

Transit: A 5-minute walk east from Staypineapple, at Michigan and Madison.

12:15 PM

Chicago River & Riverwalk

Walk north on Michigan Ave to the DuSable Bridge, then stroll east along the Riverwalk toward the lake.

Transit: A 10-minute walk north on Michigan Ave from Cindy's.

1:00 PM

Navy Pier

Ride the Centennial Wheel for views back over the skyline.

Transit: About a 25-minute walk east from the Riverwalk along the lakefront. Tired legs: the #29 bus runs along Grand Ave.

2:00 PM

Magnificent Mile

Head west to Michigan Ave, then north past Tribune Tower to the historic Water Tower. The LEGO Store at Water Tower Place is a good stop for the boys.

Transit: Walk west on Grand Ave to Michigan (about 20 min), or take the #29 bus. Then walk north on Michigan to the Water Tower (about 15 min).

3:00 PM

Lincoln Park Zoo

Free. Lions, gorillas, and the farm. Closing is usually around 4:00 in November, so confirm hours and aim for an hour here.

Transit: #151 bus north from Michigan Ave & Chicago Ave to Stockton & Webster (about 20 min).

4:15 PM

Pick up bags & check in at the Hyatt

Rideshare from the zoo, stopping at Staypineapple for bags (about 45 min in rush hour).

Transit: With bags, a rideshare is easiest. Without the bag stop: #151 bus back to State St, then the Green Line south.

6:00 PM

Dinner in Chinatown

About 5 minutes from the hotel. An easy meal after a long walking day.

Transit: #21 Cermak bus west from the hotel (about 10 min), or a 5-minute rideshare.

Fri, Nov 6

Science morning, then Evanston

8:30 AM

Breakfast at the hotel

Fuel up for the museum.

9:15 AM

Museum of Science and Industry

About 15 minutes south of the Hyatt. Be there for the 9:30 opening. Prioritize the coal mine, U-505 submarine, and Science Storms. Skip advance tickets: redeem free reciprocal admission at the ticket counter with your Space Center Houston membership card and a photo ID (up to 2 adults and 2 kids under 18). Coal mine and U-505 tours cost extra.

Transit: Metra Electric from McCormick Place to 55th-56th-57th St, then a 10-minute walk (about 25 min). Trains can be 30–60 min apart, so check the schedule.

12:00 PM

Lunch at MSI

Eat on site before your ride.

1:00 PM

Friend picks you up at MSI

About 45–60 min to Evanston by car.

2:00 PM

Afternoon in Evanston

Time with your friends. The lakefront is a short walk from their place.

6:00 PM

Dinner with friends

554 Sheridan Square, Apt 2. A rideshare back to the Hyatt takes about 40–50 min.

Transit: Rideshare back is easiest. By transit: Purple Line to Howard, Red Line to Roosevelt, then Green Line to Cermak-McCormick Place (about 75 min).

Sat, Nov 7

One last museum, then home

8:30 AM

Breakfast & check out

Ask the hotel to hold your bags.

9:00 AM

Field Museum

About 10 minutes from the Hyatt. Go straight to SUE the T. rex, then the dinosaur hall and Egyptian tomb.

Transit: Metra Electric one stop to Museum Campus/11th St, then a 10-minute walk (about 20 min).

11:15 AM

Back to hotel, early lunch

Pick up bags and eat before leaving for the airport.

Transit: Metra Electric from Museum Campus/11th St to McCormick Place, or a 10-minute rideshare.

12:15 PM

Leave for Midway

Southwest flight WN 2939 departs at 2:55 PM. About 25–35 min by car. Aim to arrive by about 1:15 PM.

Transit: Green Line to Roosevelt, then Orange Line to Midway (about 45 min). Leave by 12:00 if taking the train.

Good to know

Book timed tickets for the Field Museum ahead of time. For the Museum of Science and Industry, reciprocal membership admission can’t be reserved in advance, so redeem it in person at the ticket counter with your membership card and a photo ID, and call (773) 684-1414 beforehand to confirm the benefit. Check November hours on each museum’s site.

Getting around from the Hyatt: it’s connected to the McCormick Place Metra Electric station (best for the museums) and a 10-minute walk from the Cermak-McCormick Place Green Line station (best for downtown).

You can tap a credit card or phone to pay on CTA trains and buses. Buy Metra tickets in the Ventra app, and check the current rules for kids’ fares.

Expect highs in the 40s–50s with wind off the lake. Pack hats and gloves.

Thursday afternoon is about 3 miles on foot. The #29 and #151 buses can cut out the longest stretches when legs get tired.